JOB HUNT KILL CHAIN

Modern TTPs for the Modern Job Market

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1 - SUCCESS STORY

As a servicemember, I was completely average. I transitioned from the U.S. Marine Corps as a junior Captain and an IT Officer. In service, I made no special connections to the private sector or government. I am not from a particularly well connected family. I did not leave the service guaranteed a private sector job because of some amazing skill or connection. I EASd with no clear next job like most service members do.

I did everything the service told me to do in transition. I attended TRS and Skillbridge. I tried all of the transition tricks and tactics. I networked, did informational interviews, and tried to find the “third door”. I did what most service members did, convert my military experience into private sector experience and try to fit in. Over 6 months, it didn't work at all.

So I made a plan and I built a system to guarantee me a callback from any job that was actually hiring. The sensor to shooter kill chain and warfighting functions that made the Marines so effective at finding and destroying targets in the fog of war proved to be just as effective at finding and taking down a job in a chaotic market. After beginning my job search by these methods on September 1st, I had accepted the perfect offer for the job of my dreams by September 8th. I didn't stop there, I continued to apply to open roles and got 13 callbacks from 13 positions over the next 2 weeks. My wife, another veteran in a completely different career field, tried it too and got callbacks from dozens of positions.

Again, there is nothing special about me, so the methods laid out in this manual aren’t uniquely designed around me. This manual is designed around the objective processes that changed my job search. I wrote this so that it can be put to work for you too.

2 - UNDERSTANDING THE JOB MARKET

In order to acquire a desirable job in a complex and competitive job market, applicants must understand the current job environment in terms of the constraints it poses to both the hiring organization and job seekers..

First, the job acquisition process is a contest of competing wills in which the applicant desires high compensation at the lowest possible effort and the hiring organization desires high effort at the lowest possible monetary compensation. The acquisition operation from the friendly force perspective is oriented on how to identify the right opportunity and to capitalize on it quickly.

Many complex factors influence the challenges presented by the current job market. In military operations, PMESII standing for Political, Military, Economic, Social, Information, and Infrastructure is the categorization framework that describes the broad operational variables that influence the military environment. In the job acquisition environment this can be adapted (substituting "Military" for “Organizational”) to POESII to describe the factors that will influence the contest to acquire the right job.

- **Political**: Political policy drives the economy and growth of industries and thus has a significant impact on the job market.
- **Organizational**: Trends in organizational structures like talent acquisition pipelines and human resources departments influence how a job seeker interacts with a hiring organization.
- **Economic**: Economic trends influence the growth of industries and directly drives the expansion or reduction in the labor force within specific career fields.
- **Social**: Social trends (and increasingly social media) influences the other factors and can drive change in how organizations hire and interact with talent. Social media also directs job seekers to specific fields and changes the competitiveness of the field based on current trends.
- **Information**: Communication systems and the internet have drastically changed how job seekers identify positions and apply. Remote positions have changed the economics of talent acquisition. New systems like Greenhouse and Workable have changed how job seekers are screened and selected for positions.
- **Infrastructure**: Today, technologies like Artificial Intelligence (AI) have drastically changed the value of labor in specific fields. However, these tools influence both sides of the job acquisition contest and provide advantage to the job seeker in their ability to find, assess, and apply for positions.

Today, the job market has evolved to pose unique challenges to a job seeker. As a compounding result of the above factors, the job market is saturated with noise and highly volatile. These unique obstacles must be considered to have success in the current market:

- When open positions are posted, they can be filled with hundreds of applicants within the first 24 hours. **To overcome this, the job seeker must monitor job sources daily and apply for new positions within 24 hours of the original post to be considered.**

- Job openings are highly competitive and hiring organizations expect tailored resumes that directly reflect all the required and preferred job requirements listed in the description. **To overcome this, the job seeker must tailor every resume to the position being applied for.**

- Many posted positions are a front to assess available talent on the market and are not actually hiring new talent for the position. Additionally, job posts stay up until the selected applicant signs the contract and begins onboarding, this falsely advertises an open position for days or weeks when the hiring organization does not intend on investigating new applicants. **To mitigate the risk of wasted effort, a job seeker needs to screen job posts carefully and reduce the labor and time involved in tailoring and submitting an application (see above point on tailoring applications).**

- Recruiters and HR personnel are not normally subject matter experts on the skills involved in the position they screen for. This means they cannot interpret or translate information relating to the position and often rely on simple tactics like keyword matching to identify qualified candidates. **To overcome this, a job seeker must present a resume and application that explicitly lays out the required attributes clearly without needing interpretation, translation, or inference.**

Cross-functional job seekers often encounter additional obstacles in the current market:

- Job descriptions are often hyperspecific and penalize generalist resumes. While many positions actually require diverse and cross functional skills to be successful in the role, the hiring organization is looking only for the specific skills advertised in a job opening. Hiring organizations look for the unique and often unlikely combination of skills that are needed for the responsibilities of the position and nothing else. **To overcome this, the job seeker must produce a resume and application that includes only directly relevant skills, experience, titles, and certifications, and omit other information.**

- Being overqualified for a position in terms of scope of responsibility or years of experience is often intimidating to hiring organizations. **To overcome this, a job seeker must appropriately scope the experience and responsibility shown in their application without overselling or underselling their qualifications.**

- Cross functional job seekers may be qualified for multiple distinct positions and may struggle to identify one resume that articulates all required skills. **To overcome this, a job seeker must maintain separate and distinct career narratives for each individually appreciable role to ensure they adequately represent their competence.**

The traditional job hunt process of assembling a quality resume from impressive professional experience and expecting the hiring organization to infer competence in the posted position no

longer works. The modern environment and labor market requires a more agile, targeted approach to acquiring a desired job to allow job seekers to cut through the noise.

3 - THE PROCESS - JOB HUNT KILL CHAIN

I - DEVELOPING MARKET INTELLIGENCE

Understanding the Adversary System

In order to compete with the hiring organization, it is important to understand the system of personnel, their functional roles, and the technologies and processes they leverage to advertise open positions, identify talent, and screen for the best candidate.

Talent Acquisition Roles

Hiring organizations typically have departments designed around Human Resources with subsections specializing in talent acquisition. These sections can be arrayed by function (technical recruiters vs non-technical recruiters) seniority of position (recruiters and executive recruiters) or by their relationship to the hiring organization (in-house recruiter, agency recruiter, or contract/temporary recruiter). The notable distinctions are:

- **Recruiters** are talent acquisition specialists who align open positions to available talent. They advertise jobs, screen applicants, and generally manage and take responsibility for the talent acquisition process prior to the candidate signing a contract and becoming a new employee. Recruiters partner with hiring managers to fill positions.

- **Senior Recruiters** are often less involved in the direct tactics and mechanics of screening talent. Senior recruiters often advise hiring organization executives and influence recruiting strategy by tracking market and industry trends in salary and skills match.

- **Technical Recruiters** are specialists who recruit specifically for science, technology, engineering, and math (STEM) based positions. They typically have functional literacy but are not experts in the positions they recruit for.

- **Executive Search Recruiters** specialize in hiring top level leadership and executives and are often referred to as “headhunters” because they routinely seek out executive candidates instead of waiting for them to apply.

- **Contract or Temporary Recruiters** are brought into an organization to supplement a shortfall during surge times or for specific high volume periods. They are not natives of the organization and likely cannot answer more than cursory questions about the position or organization.

- **Recruiting Agencies** are third party outsourcing agencies that handle recruiting for a hiring organization. Recruiters in these organizations screen candidates then elevate them to the hiring organization to reduce volume. These recruiters are often incentivized to fill contracts quickly and normally prioritize filling a position above the overall match for the position. Their goal is to find talent, not to build or manage a functioning team.

Applicant Tracking Systems

An applicant tracking system is a software hiring organizations use to organize and automate their hiring and recruitment processes. Despite popular belief, most ATS does not eliminate candidates using artificial intelligence. Automation should not be confused with “AI”; while ATS automates administrative processes like scheduling interviews, sending status updates, and communicating between hiring organization hiring teams, commonly used systems do not delegate screening decisions to AI agents.

ATS is structurally a centralized database collecting and connecting position descriptions with application forms, resumes, and cover letters. ATS parses the information in an applicant package to make it searchable to the hiring team. This means that, in practice, the resume a job seeker submits has the content pulled out and turned into normal plain text so that a recruiter or hiring manager can find the applicant by searching for terms or attributes.

Often ATS can assist the hiring team by ranking candidates based on keyword matches and increasingly, AI assessments. However, a human being on the hiring team is responsible for searching the overwhelming collection of applications and quickly assessing the value of a potential candidate.

ATS is designed to reduce information overload for the hiring organization. While not intended to pose an obstacle to the job seeker, it may if the constraints of the system are not well understood.

Government, Contract and Subcontract, Private, and Public Jobs

Different position types have drastically different application considerations:

- Government and Public Sector jobs use centralized job portals like USAJOBS, are very slow and bureaucratic (and can take 3 to 6 months from initial application to a job offer), and require a long and highly structured resume style. ATS for these positions checks for very strict eligibility status (like current civil service or veteran status) and will eliminate non-eligible applicants before a human ever receives their application. Government and public sector jobs will stay open and continue evaluating applicants until the application period is closed.

- Contract and Subcontract jobs are often filled by recruiting agencies and can actively recruit job seekers with appropriate skills through sites like LinkedIn or Clearance Jobs. Contact jobs tend to be filled very quickly (in days or weeks) and look for niche technical skills and immediate availability. ATS and hiring processes check for basic eligibility like background check or security clearance verification. Contract jobs will actively evaluate candidates on a rolling basis until the position is filled and will rush candidates to the final hiring decision unless obviously unfit.

- Private sector jobs have more casual hiring processes assessing culture fit and adaptable skills. Private jobs are less likely to actively recruit and job seekers will need to seek these positions out and compete for attention. Private jobs tend to be filled over

multiple weeks, falling between government and contract in terms of speed. ATS and hiring processes check for basic eligibility like background checks and are more lenient than the other types of jobs.

Application Criteria

Job descriptions advertise what the hiring organization is looking for in a candidate. The requirements and preferences in the job description are not suggestions, they define what the recruiter will screen for to reduce the volume of candidates. A single candidate trying to stand out in a crowd of hundreds must meet the criteria or risk being eliminated from the pool in favor of the many candidates who check more of the advertised boxes. Criteria are separated as:

- **Eligibility Requirements** define legal and administrative requirements that make a job seeker eligible to be considered for the position. Note, with few exceptions, no amount of qualification can counteract lack of eligibility. Many organizations are audited and must report hiring actions and will be scrutinized to ensure compliance with the eligibility requirements. A job seeker must ensure they are eligible for a position they are applying for with very few exceptions. ATS will reject or remove applications that are not assessed as eligible for the position. These fields are typically pulled out specifically in application forms. Typical eligibility requirements are citizenship status, education level, physical abilities or ability to perform specific functions, or location. Eligibility is easily verifiable.

- **Required Qualifications** define the baseline qualifications that allow a candidate to successfully perform the job. Note, that while eligibility requirements are typically very objectively verifiable and binary, required qualifications can be more intangible. Core skills, for example, typically do not require industry certification, license, or degrees and can be attested by the job seeker alone. Required qualifications are not easily verifiable.

- **Job Responsibilities** are the duties that are associated with the position. These criteria are typically action oriented and bulletized and outline what tangible and intangible things the position will entail. Examples are “Manages a portfolio of 12 technical projects” or “Liaises between core engineering teams and customers”. The hiring organization needs to be left with the impression that the job seeker can confidently and competently own those responsibilities (typically by having successfully done so in a comparable previous position). Job responsibilities are verifiable by reference only.

- **Preferred Qualifications** outline attributes that would make a candidate more competitive for the position but will not eliminate a candidate from eligibility or qualification should they not have it. Despite this, with the competitive nature of most positions, an organization is ever increasingly likely to be presented with candidates that offer preferred qualifications. These skills or qualifications typically allow an employee who possesses them to start producing value faster (like pre-existing familiarity with the company’s platforms, services, or industry). Preferred qualifications are often intangible, like “experience with healthcare technology” or “experience mentoring teammates”. Preferred qualifications are not easily verifiable.

Talent Acquisition Timelines and Logistics

Hiring processes combine actions from multiple individuals and require coordination of schedules and time. Depending on how competitive or urgent the hiring need is, a qualified applicant can generally expect to hear back from the hiring organization within two weeks. The general rule of thumb is that if an organization has not reached out and expressed interest within 2 weeks of receiving a job seeker's application, then they likely will not. Additionally, a job posting remaining online does not mean the hiring organization is actually evaluating applicants. The post will typically stay up (and be reposted periodically to stay fresh) until a desired candidate is through the interview process, the screening process, passes any background check or eligibility checks, signs the contract, and checks in on their first day. The hiring organization is mitigating risk by continuing to advertise the position in case their desired candidate does not commit to the job.

- As an example, an opening for a manager position was posted on the 15th of August. A qualified candidate applied on August 16th and was contacted (along with 7 other promising candidates) by a recruiter on August 28th. Post phone screening, 5 candidates were scheduled for virtual interviews with the hiring manager, 3 were scheduled for skiplevel (manager's manager) interviews, 2 for panel interviews on site. The final candidate was sent an offer letter on September 9th. Negotiation ensued and the offer was signed September 15th. The candidate passed a background check and reported to work on September 21st. The job posting stayed up until September 21st and was reposted every 3 days as new. No candidates applying after August 25th were considered. In this case, the position still being shown as "open" for weeks does not indicate that the hiring organization is desperate, it indicates that the position has likely already found a candidate.

Reposting Tactics

Hiring organizations are competing for the attention of talented candidates in an automation assisted battleground covering multiple online job boards. Every hour, several jobs are posted to the site and each are inundated with applications. So, the hiring agency's posted position will fall below more recent posts in the queue and will thus lose the attention of potential talented candidates. To combat this, hiring organizations employ automated reposting systems that repost the position on a routine schedule to ensure it shows at the top of the job queue. This obscures the age of the post and makes it difficult for a job seeker to discern where in the hiring process the position is and if they will be considered if they apply. So, a position showing as recently posted does not mean it is fresh.

II - PERFORMING MARKET RECONNAISSANCE

Identify Source Quality

Open job positions are advertised redundantly in multiple places for different purposes, not all the avenues of application are equal. Each should be considered and utilized for its affordances and limitations:

- **Company Websites** and career portals hold the authoritative source of truth for positions and are maintained more readily than the other sites. Applications on the company website are more likely to interface perfectly with the hiring organization's ATS given that they are designed to be interoperable and connected. This lowers the likelihood of mistakes (missing, misrepresented, or scrambled information) in transmission of the application data.
- **Online Job Boards** often link directly to the hiring organization's original authoritative post. Hiring organizations desire to reach the widest audience possible with each job post and leverage online job boards for most positions with few exceptions. This makes online job sites an area of interest for a job seeker. Reconnoitering the job boards requires searching for jobs daily and taking logs of what positions are posted to compare daily so that reposted stale jobs can be identified and ignored. Best practice is to log the desirable jobs each day to feed the application cycle, then start each day comparing the existing jobs to the previously recorded jobs. Popular online job boards include:
    - **Indeed** - best for high-volume, broad-spectrum job hunting across almost any industry or experience level.
    - **LinkedIn Jobs** - best for white-collar, mid-to-senior level roles, and active professional networking.
    - **Clearance Jobs** - best for U.S. citizens who hold an active federal security clearance (Secret, Top Secret, TS/SCI, etc.).
    - **Dice** - best for Information Technology (IT), software engineering, cybersecurity, cloud computing, and tech contract roles entry level to engineer excluding leadership.
    - **USAJOBS** - best for official U.S. federal government employment.
    - **FlexJobs** - best for legitimate remote, hybrid, freelance, part-time, and flexible schedule jobs.
    - **Idealist** - best for nonprofits, social-impact organizations, charities, and volunteering.

While online job boards offer convenience and quick application features for the job seeker, be wary, there is no guarantee that the job board is perfectly interoperable with the hiring organization ATS. As a result, application information may be misrepresented or incomplete, which effectively eliminates the chances of success in application.

- **Social Media Posts** are valuable in that they convey background information on the hiring situation and need. Hiring organizations utilize social media posts to advertise open positions, therefore a job seeker should monitor social media accounts for organizations within their accessible working area to identify promising positions early. Talent acquisition personnel, hiring managers, and potential referrers often post links to positions from their personal accounts to increase exposure.

  Additional search parameters like “I’m Hiring”, “My Team is Hiring”, “Looking For A”, and “DM me” alongside the position keywords can be beneficial for finding active positions with legitimate hiring need or urgency.

When corroborating multiple overlapping job sources, a job seeker must maintain the hierarchy of authority, prioritizing more authoritative information when present. If a social media post and an authoritative career portal job posting differ, the career portal post is more likely accurate.

Use Filters and Keywords Smartly

Online job sources can host an overwhelming volume of positions with many being irrelevant to the job seeker. Using filters and keyword searches can reduce the scope of search. However, not all organizations conform to standard naming conventions or position titles. So, before conducting a search, a job seeker should research what a specific hiring organization labels the appropriate position to ensure those positions are not missed by a keyword search. A job seeker should be evaluating the roles the hiring organization has open, not simply searching for their desired job title at the organization.

- For example, aerospace company SpaceX refers to their technical project manager or customer liaison role as “Mission Success Engineer”, this position is not part of their core engineering and a keyword search for the generic project manager role would miss this role.

No single search will return all positions so a job seeker must deliberately overlap searches by title, skill, company, and location to ensure opportunities are not overlooked. Best practice is to create search matrices with all combinations of the following factors: role type and synonyms, company, work location, and job source. This mitigates the unpredictability of searching the job boards.

- A search for “Project Manager” will show different positions on LinkedIn and Indeed.
- By scanning Lockheed’s career page without any other fixed filters, a job seeker may find a unique position they didn’t know to search for.

Set Up Alerts

Online job boards empower job seekers with passive monitoring and alerting functions like automatic email updates to reduce the volume of positions a job seeker should screen. Be wary, however, that these screening systems are imperfect and frequently alert for undesired positions and frequently miss potentially desirable positions that may be listed on the site. These systems largely use keyword matching or attribute matching based on the job seeker's established profile and are logically imperfect as a result. This system can be used to supplement easily identifiable jobs but should not be relied on as a precise source of truth for all job opportunities.

Search Cadence

Job sources change dynamically so a frequent routine of searching the sources ensures opportunities are not missed. Best practice is to recon for jobs in two parts with one in depth sweep early in the day and one short sweep later in the day.

III - TRACKING THE OPERATION

Organizing the Operation

To be successful in a job hunt campaign, a job seeker must develop a feedback loop that allows them to improve their tactics and products for every application. To achieve this, a job seeker must organize every application and all related products into a single clear personal workflow. Best practice is to use a Kanban board that organizes applications by their stage in the process from the backlog, through researching, applying, waiting, interview preparation, interviewing, offer, and negotiation. This simplifies the flow of applications and artifacts into an easily digestible dashboard that serves as a battle tracking system and a log book for each job.

Track Actions and Interactions

Every interaction (or lack thereof) conveys information about the success or failure of the application. A job seeker should track posting trends, information interviews and inquiries, LinkedIn or social media traffic or interest as well as application status.

Analyze Trends

With data collected on every job application, the trends will be easy to assess. Each stage of the process and the outcome gives the job seeker insight on what to improve.

- If resumes and applications do not receive callbacks, the resume needs to be improved.
- If resumes get a phone screening but no additional interest, the phone screening preparation needs work.
- If the phone screening leads to a virtual interview but the process halts there, the interview process must be improved.

Job seekers can get feedback even when no information is given by the hiring organization. When an organization hires for a position, the individual who is hired often posts on social media that they've accepted a new position. By searching LinkedIn for the position after the job posting has closed, the job seeker can find the profile of whoever was hired and compare themselves and their application to learn and improve.

Assess Effects

When applying to jobs in high volume, it is beneficial to test different tactics and products using evolutionary natural selection strategies and A/B testing. If stuck at an early stage of the process, the job seeker should implement controlled changes to batches of applications and study if the change had any effect on the outcome before implementing it fully into the workflow.

- For example, a job seeker may test a new resume structure for ATS compatibility on 5 resumes or a new more direct professional summary on 5 resumes. These changes should be implemented individually on the best common baseline product to control for confounding variables.

Reduce the Noise

To avoid clutter and distraction, a job seeker should reduce the volume of job applications in progress. In practice, if a hiring organization has not followed up for an interview within two weeks of a prompt application, a job seeker can consider the opportunity passed. These jobs should be archived for reference and retrieval if they do lead to an interview later but should not be considered live opportunities beyond two weeks of silence. Best practice is to automate the archival of stale jobs after two weeks of waiting to avoid distracting the job seeker.

IV - ACHIEVING DESIRED EFFECTS IN APPLICATIONS

A successful job application capitalizes on an opportunity presented by the hiring organization. From the job description and research, a successful application identifies a desired effect on the hiring organization, assembles resources to achieve the desired effect, and presents said resources at the appropriate point in the hiring organization system to be noticed, understood, and desired.

- Job applications are analogous to fishing in a stream saturated with other fishermen. A successful catch occurs at the intersection of the right bait to attract the fish, the right hook to secure the fish, the right timing when a fish is present and no other fisherman has hooked it yet, and the right physical location to ensure the fish notices the bait at all. A successful job application must accomplish all of this at once. The job seeker's bait, hook, and line are the resume. The fish is a job opening.

Requirements First Resume Generation

Traditional resume building processes begin with the job seeker's own experience and work to whittle or inflate their achievements and responsibilities to mimic those desired in the job description. This is inherently backwards as it fails to orient on the root of the problem: the

hiring organization's system does not care about the job seeker, it cares about solving the underlying problem that the position is designed around. The recruiter or hiring manager may be unable to recognize the talent being presented by the job seeker's resume and application if it is presented from the perspective of the job seeker instead of the hiring organization.

To mitigate this, job seekers must build "requirements first" resumes. **This process begins with advertised job requirements and overlays the job seeker's experience onto it** and results in a professional presentation that is impossible for the hiring organization to ignore or misinterpret. To accomplish this a job seeker must:

- Review the posted requirements and skills on the job description. Decompose complex requirements into their smallest form as necessary. For example, "be able to coordinate and organize multiple complex projects while managing non-technical stakeholders" can be decomposed to "Organize multiple complex projects" and "Manage non-technical stakeholders".

- For each job requirement, identify a professional experience, skill, or certification that proves that they have been in that position before in a comparable scope and achieved a high impact outcome.

As a result of orienting on the requirements first, the resume becomes transparent to the hiring organization and surfaces only relevant information that proves the job seeker is a perfect match for the position.

Note, hiring organizations use job descriptions to outline the baseline specifications they need in an applicant. Consider the job description like an engineering requirements list; if a candidate were being built from scratch, the hiring organization would pay for all of the requirements listed. Therefore, an applicant must present themselves not as unrealized potential or as a substitute for the specifications, but as a perfect match for the skills and attributes requested.

Front Load Impact

Recruiters and hiring managers review many job applications and resumes in a hiring period. They skim resumes and applications for promising highlights to save time and speed up the overall hiring process. So, a job hunter hoping to make an impression must front load the most engaging and relevant information in the resume to increase the chances that a recruiter or hiring manager is hooked by the content as they skim the first page. Only after gaining their attention in the first half of the first page will a recruiter give attention to the rest of the resume.

This applies to the full resume, not just professional experiences:

- Core skills, if heavily requested on the job description, should be listed on the first page.

- Education, if an eligibility requirement, should be listed on the first page.

- Any intangible attributes requested, should be listed in the professional summary at the top of the first page.

- Any certifications preferred or required should be represented on the first page.

This is the job seeker's opportunity to catch and maintain the attention of the hiring organization. Information on the second page, regardless of how attractive, will not be seen if the first page (the intro and first half) does not catch the attention of the reviewer.

Chronological and Functional Resumes

Resumes can be presented chronologically (organized by time like a single narrative) or functionally (organized into categories to show coverage of multiple core areas). It is widely known that humans digest information better when it is presented in the form of a story, so it is no surprise that recruiters and hiring managers prefer chronological resumes to functional resumes. However, humans also prefer receiving categorized and sorted information over randomized or disorganized information. So, typical chronological resumes are unsatisfactory by design because they represent professional attributes by time at the expense of categorization and concentration.

For veterans or cross functional job seekers, standard chronological resumes appear disorganized and often under-represent professional skills and responsibilities because they are distributed amongst various roles over time. For example, a Military Company Commander or Senior Enlisted Advisor has professional skills in operations, leadership and management, project management, change management, specific technologies and tools relevant to their trade, and may have achieved impactful outcomes over their entire career rising through the ranks. However, when a chronological resume is assembled, it breaks the concentration of skills and requires the recruiter or hiring manager to search the resume experience section to build an understanding of one specific set of skills.

Functional resumes concentrate skills and impact together to make a more compelling argument for the competency in an area. For veterans or multi-role job seekers, standard functional resumes are difficult to understand and internalize as they lack narrative flow. The recruiter may have difficulty overlaying the presented experience on the candidate's persona and story without a history that helps explain that experience, how and when it was earned, and how it benefited past organizations in similar contexts.

Best practice is to write a hybrid resume that presents a simple narrative chronologically but organizes functions and professional attributes into contiguous episodes like a functional resume. This leverages both benefits: familiar presentation and organized content.

- For example, an IT Manager who participates in both hands on engineering and leadership should consider organizing their chronological resume into distinct episodes of "IT Manager" covering scope of responsibility, number of direct reports, and team performance improvement and separately "IT Engineer" covering specific technologies and platforms used, number of devices or appliances managed, and the operational impacts achieved by their technical contributions. These may have occurred in the same role, but they are easier to represent and more impactful when concentrated into titled positions that showcase only the specific function. The goal is for the candidate to be

perceived as a manager and an engineer, not just a manager who dabbles in engineering occasionally.

- A veteran or experienced cross-functional job seeker may be more qualified for a specific role than a candidate who only performed that role but may not be seen as qualified without the concentrated resume representation. For example, a Commissioned Officer or Staff Noncommissioned Officer has fulfilled the functions of an Operations Manager and may be better in practice than a private sector Operations Manager. However, the hiring organization has no way of translating this difference. A job seeker should not leave it up to the recruiter to identify their competency. While the hiring organization will understand that an Operations Manager in a different job sector has different experience, they will not understand that a Company Commander or Operations Chief is an equivalent experience.

Logical Professional Progression

Professional narratives in hybrid resumes need to be organized to best represent the progression of skills and responsibilities in a logical and easily understandable way. This should be prioritized even if the most accurate representation of the order and timing of skills would disagree. The order, timing, and grouping of skills and accomplishments associated with each distinct professional role exist only to assist with the conveyance of professional competency and are not verifiable or independently significant. The job seeker should organize their professional experience in a manner that reflects how the hiring organization understands the typical progression to the open position.

- For example, a Tiered IT Support system is comparable to a junior, senior, team leader IT support system. A senior support specialist's experience may be misunderstood by the hiring organization if not represented in an understandable way. So, the job seeker could translate their past roles to the equivalent (or closest matching) position recognized by the hiring organization to make the progression understandable. This can be learned by independently researching the development pathway to the advertised position and replicating that.

ATS Compatibility and Formatting

Resumes are inputs to the hiring organization ATS and are parsed by the system to create referenceable and searchable data fields. Therefore, it is vital that resumes be designed to be compatible with ATS first and visually appealing second. If a resume is incompatible with ATS, it likely will never be reviewed by a human recruiter. Common ATS incompatibility errors include:

- Complex Layouts can interrupt ATS parsing systems and result in information being omitted from the resulting output.

- Visual Elements cannot be parsed by the ATS system and as a result, break up parsed information and take up space with no benefit.

- Nonstandard Date Formatting can be translated incorrectly and may represent eligibility requirements like years of experience or career continuity incorrectly as a result. Sections may be logically ordered incorrectly in the ATS based on faulty date parsing.
- Headers or Footers are often inaccessible to the ATS parsing tool since they exist outside the document body area and may result in key information being omitted.
- Incorrect File Types like PNG or JPG may result in the resume being rejected or failing to parse as ATS relies on parsable DOCX or PDF formatting.
- Stylized Characters may fail to parse or be translated as random values which may appear unprofessional or confusing to the reviewing recruiter or may inhibit key word or phrase matching.

Best practice is to generate a plain and professional resume with no interesting formatting, layouts, visual effects, or stylized characters. Standardize spacing and fonts. Use standard short date format (MM/YYYY) or long date format (Month YYYY). Remove headers and footers and begin the resume in the body area of the document. Export as a PDF to preserve formatting.

Know Where to Apply

Not all application portals are equally integrated into the hiring organization's hiring process. When able, a job seeker should apply through the hiring organization's careers or job opening portal directly. This system is typically integrated into the hiring process directly and is unlikely to be ignored by the hiring organization. Often, third party sites hosting job openings are inadvertently also configured to accept applications as standard functionality for the site. These applications often do not connect to the hiring organization ATS or must be checked deliberately.

"Easy Apply" tools on job board sites should be avoided. These tools often improperly fill information even within the site and largely fail to seamlessly integrate with hiring organization ATS due to poor configuration by the hiring team. As a result, easy apply applications are frequently misrepresented, incomplete, or never submitted to the ATS at all.

Cover Letters and Application Questions

Cover letters have largely fallen in popularity due to the increase in online forms for application info. Cover letters are not a restatement of the resume information. A good cover letter answers: why the candidate wants the job, why the candidate is a uniquely good fit for the job, and why the candidate wants to work at the specific organization. Where a resume provides evidence of the competence and experience of the job seeker, a cover letter attests to the motivation, passion, and culture fit.

Best practice is to identify a standout trait or unique connection to the company, product, or mission and to highlight it with an anecdote. Cover letters and application questions are

designed to show that the candidate is passionate about the hiring organization or is uniquely valuable for the position.

V - INFLUENCING THE SYSTEM

In the modern job environment, it is not enough to simply apply and cede the initiative to the hiring organization. A job seeker should, through understanding the hiring organization's system, identify and influence the personnel involved in the process to gain advantage beyond the standard application. The hiring organization and the hiring process are composed of individuals who each perceive and are biased by intangible factors beyond the job application. By maintaining a professional presence, strong information security practices, and by tactfully engaging with the hiring organization, a job seeker can consistently gain advantage.

Presence on Social Media

Much like the dating process through an app; in the hiring process, the job seeker's image will strongly influence how hiring organizations perceive value in the candidate. Do not advertise weakness. It is imperative to remember that hiring organizations can and will investigate a candidate's social media and will form judgements based on what they find.

- **Never openly post about extended unemployment due to an inability to find a job.** This conveys that no other organization desired the candidate, so why would the hiring organization desire the candidate?

- **Never complain about the unfairness of the job market publicly.** This conveys that the candidate is noncompetitive in the job market.

- **Never advertise being laid off or fired.** Although it is honest, it conveys that the candidate did not provide enough value to their previous organization to justify continued employment.

- **Never post political or personal posts.** The hiring personnel may disagree with or not understand the nature of these posts or perspectives and it may create bad impressions unintentionally.

An analogy to dating:

"My long time romantic partner (whom I thought I would marry) dumped me suddenly. I have asked dozens of people out in the past four months and nobody has given me the time of day. I am losing confidence that I will find the right person … oh hi Anduril! Do *you* want to go out with me?"

Social media management is basic OPSEC. There is no possibility that a hiring organization will pity the job seeker and offer them a job. The job market is not a charity. A military would never consider directly reporting casualties and operational struggles to the adversary on an open radio net. So, the job seeker should never consider directly communicating nonessential or nonenhancing information to the hiring organization. All social media that others can see is an

extension of the individual's professional persona. All professional social media is an extension of the job seeker's resume.

Influencing Recruiters, Hiring Managers, and Potential Referrers

Recruiters, hiring managers, and potential referrers are normally active on social media both individually and through their organizations. So, a job seeker can influence the personnel responsible for reviewing their application both passively and actively.

- If a recruiter or hiring manager advertises a job on their LinkedIn, Instagram, X, or other public post platform, they are inviting interested candidates to engage with them. Job seekers should respond to the post with interest in addition to following any included application steps. Responding to the post makes the post originator aware of the candidate's name, face, and existence which can give the candidate a subtle advantage through recognizability.

Advertising Interest

Hiring organizations are looking for a job candidate that is both a good fit for the position and for the organization culture. Culture matches assess the intangibles like values, interests, and personality. Recruiters will use any information available to them to screen out candidates who do not match the organization's culture and to investigate those who do. A job seeker should be mindful and deliberate about what they publicly like, comment on, or engage with on social media because it advertises their potential culture fitness to hiring organizations. Job seekers should like or follow the organization they are applying for on the appropriate professional social media platform (likely LinkedIn) to demonstrate interest. Further, candidates should review the mission, vision, or any cultural pillars or values of the organization and use them tactfully in their application and communications:

- For example, Brooks Running advertises the value "Runner First" to show their focus on their customer base. A job seeker should use this value tactfully in their correspondence to show that they align with the organization's culture. An appropriate place is in the professional summary section as it is freeform text with a personal focus or in the personal cover letter. This should not be repeated verbatim at risk of sounding ingenuine, a tactful summarization or paraphrase is appropriate. A job seeker may write in the summary "An experienced product owner skilled in aligning organization resources to deliver customer value" or may include a cover letter section about how they model this value.

When engaging with the hiring organization, the job seeker should frame the hiring organization as the hero and themself as the hero's guide. The hiring organization is looking for the right candidate that can help them achieve their goals, not a generically impressive candidate that has achieved generically impressive goals themself.

Visual Appearances

Despite how the hiring process begins, appearances matter. The system itself is designed to be unbiased but cannot remove the human preference for the attractive over the unattractive. With this in mind, it is vitally important that job seekers present themselves flatteringly and professionally in all images across all platforms. Profile photos on all accounts should be professional in nature, clean headshots only with simple and non-distracting backgrounds of a single color. Job seekers should take any appropriate aesthetic maintenance actions appropriate for their appearance (maintaining hair, skin, etc) so as to appear professional and composed. Simple smiles convey trustworthiness, so job seekers should smile in professional photos. Off-angle or “selfie” photos should be avoided as they show less preparation.

AI can be used to tactfully touch up professional photos or make modifications of pose, angle, lighting, or background. Job seekers should take a reference photo as close to the desired output as realistically possible to avoid the tell-tale signs of AI photo generation (smudging and poor proportions) to avoid uncanny photos and bad impressions. A professional headshot is always better than an AI generated headshot but an AI headshot is better than an unprofessional photo.

4 - CONCLUSION

This manual outlines that success in the modern job market requires a systematic approach that orients on the hiring organization's system first. By treating the job search as a structured kill chain composed of sensing, fixing, targeting, applying, and influencing actions, job seekers can significantly increase their success matching with a hiring organization.

This framework can be implemented manually and remain extremely effective. A job seeker can manually recon the job boards daily and log jobs, exhaustively research the job market, track each application and interaction on a kanban board, generate requirements first hybrid resumes, and influence hiring organization personnel with targeted social media actions. However, executing this methodology consistently at scale and speed requires significant effort.

We are building the CareerC2 platform to fully automate this exact methodology. Instead of managing these complex actions manually, you can let the CareerC2 system run the framework for you. Connect with me on LinkedIn https://www.linkedin.com/in/maurice-trammell/ or via email maurice.trammell.gh@pm.me to follow the project.